Dielarity

By Lizz Winstead

LIZZY: **(Pgs 281-296)** When they took Dad to the hospital for the last time, it was my birthday; and I was celebrating in Coney Island with my sister Ann and her family. He called me from his room.

DAD: Lizzy, the paramedics asked me if I was on any medications. I told them everything but Viagra. Then they put the oxygen mask on me.

LIZZY: *(to audience)* Those were the last actual words I heard him say. It was typical of Dad: dark, inappropriate, and funny. *(to family, brightly)* We'll call him later. Let's go see the sword swallower. *(to audience)* [But] my sister Linda called back the following morning.

LINDA: *(softly, with fear in her voice)* You need to come home. Dad is dying.

LIZZY: Dad had tried to prepare me for this day. A few months before his death, he had sent me a card and had asked me not to open it "till after I'm gone." Of course I opened it immediately. The front was a photo

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of the Manhattan skyline. When I opened it, it simply said, *I love you. You are my favorite. Please don't tell the others.* The sentiment evoked a range of emotions in me at the time. It made me feel elated that I did something right. Then it made me feel bad for my brother and sisters. Finally, I felt horribly guilty for opening it.

INTRODUCTION

Have you ever laughed so hard, you cried? Or been in such a sorrowful situation that a burst of laughter escaped? Humor, especially during extremely stressful moments, has the benefit of acting like a "release valve," relieving tension — if even for a moment — so everyone can re-set and re-evaluate. It is often the glue that holds human connections together. Humor as a way of facing and coping with death: Hospice caregivers call it therapeutic humor in this selection it's called . . .

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LIZZY: Ann and I flew to Minneapolis and went straight to the hospital from the airport. As we walked toward Dad's room, the sound of laughter got louder. Dad's big double room had become a de facto hospice/party space. There was Dad, lying on his back in a heavy morphine paradise, the bedside table littered with a

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pizza box and pop cans. Mom was sitting in the chair next to him, holding a piece of pizza in one hand and Dad's hand in the other. My brother, two sisters, and sister-in-law were sitting in a row on the extra bed, tears were streaming down their faces as they laughed. They looked like little kids who were still too small to have their feet touch the floor. Dad couldn't speak, but he could hear everything. His stomach was bouncing up and down, as he was laughing, too.

ANNE: What did we miss? I hate when I miss any laughing.

GENE: *(gasping)* The meat! The gas station meat!

LIZZY: . . . my brother said, choking through what I like to think of as dielarity. *(pauses as if the audience has asked "what is dielarity?")* **dielarity:** *The dark humor created in the environment of or at the expense of someone dying.*

[And] the gas station meat was the crown jewel in the pantheon of Dad's many "deals." Dad loved getting a bargain. He mostly liked gag gifts, like the footstool with humanlike legs wearing tube socks and sneakers. Or the sixty-five-pound brass elephant phones we each

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got for Christmas one year.

Throughout his years of cruising for "deals." Dad had created a whole world for himself. There was a Vietnamese restaurant he liked with a sign: I DIDN'T COME 9,000 MILES TO COOK YOU ORDINARY FOOD. And a place he called "the Institute." -- a barber school that trained guys just out of prison to cut hair. He could get a shave and a cut for eight bucks.

DAD: I could get the basic shave for six, but I get the works for eight. When you're doing something that involves a razor and a guy just out of jail, you don't want to do it on the cheap.

LIZZY: His criteria for what to do "on the cheap" were wildly inconsistent. Which brings us back to the gas station meat. *(to family)* We were in Beanie's backyard, eating these beautiful rib eyes Dad had just grilled. *(to audience)* Dad's stomach was in full bounce.

(to family) I will never forget being halfway through my steak when you got to the part . . . *(mimicking Dad's voice)* "I was filling up the tank and notice this fella's got a station wagon there with the tailgate open. And

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the guy says, "You want to check out my meat?" And at first, I thought, Who is this weirdo who wants to show me his meat?" *(to audience, laughing)* Dad was so proud of that dumb joke. Then the story reached its climax with each of us interrupting all over the place.

ANN: *(laughing)* That guy had half a cow in an old cardboard box in the back of that station wagon.

GENE: *(laughing)* That came from God knows where! Or *when!*

LINDA: *(laughing)* And Dad bought all of it! For forty bucks!

LIZZY: *(laughing)* We were eating black market roadkill.

MOM: *(laughing)* The ribs were really very good.

LIZZY: We swapped stories for a few more hours until the dielarity exhausted us all. Dielarious laughter is different from regular laughter, as it drains you of every emotion inside you. It is an exhausting release of all the pain, fear, love, and loss that you have been holding in until your body can no longer physically take it. I freely let it happen, because if I didn't, if I had left even an ounce of energy in me, I would have spent it reminding myself that my life was about to change

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forever.

I looked at Mom gently rubbing his hand. She was eighty- four and had survived three heart attacks, but somehow she never seemed stronger.

MOM: I need to go home. . . I think tomorrow will be a long day. (kissing dad on the forehead) Night, Wilb, see ya tomorrow.

LIZZY: Her tenderness inspired a comforting confidence that we would have Dad tomorrow. [The next day] we didn't know what to do. A hospice worker suggested we each take some time alone with Dad to share our private thoughts.

And so that process began. Mom suggested we say our good- byes in birth order, which meant that I would go last. At first, I felt a bit afraid of being alone with him. His breathing pattern started sounding finite. Each inhale was a jarring gasp that seemed to come in ten-minute increments. When he exhaled, it sounded like a January wind whistling through a small crack in a window. I learned later that is what is referred to in hospice circles as a death rattle.

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I climbed into bed with him and grabbed his hand. I put my lips right up to his ear and spoke in my normal voice. "Dad, squeeze my hand so I know you can hear me." (to audience) He squeezed back. I didn't know where to start, so I started with . . . "Dad, I opened your card. I couldn't wait. I hope you are not mad. It made me feel so special." *(to audience)* He didn't squeeze my hand, but his belly started to bounce. Right then, that felt better than a squeeze.

"Dad, I am who I am because of you, and that includes the bad parts, mister! You couldn't have done a better job of being a dad. I hope you are proud of me. I love you." *Squeeze.*

I kissed him on the forehead again and went to open the door. His breathing became so shallow, so slow, that as a family we all tried to breathe for him. As a group we inhaled with him and painfully watched as he choked out an exhale, like he had breathed in a box of tacks. It was the worst thirty minutes of our lives. Each of us wanted his pain to end, and we took turns assuring him that he could go, that we would all be okay.

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Finally, he took his last breath. We all exhaled with him. His jaw slacked and my brother gently took his two fingers, closed Dad's eyes, and removed the oxygen tubes from his nose. We hadn't seen him without those tubes in years. My father used to say,

DAD: *(smiling through tears)* Next to your mother, this oxygen tank is the longest relationship I've ever had.

LIZZY: He looked rested. Yellow, but rested. I always wondered what this would feel like, but it all seemed natural. Before I could even form my first thoughts, I looked over at Mom. She was still holding his hand.

MOM: He loved you kids so much; you were his world. He always hoped he told you enough. It's why he sent you kids the cards to open after he died, so you would always have a reminder.

LIZZY: I keep mine open in my jewelry case. (to audience) Then I thought, *They **all** got cards?* I had heard that people prepared for their own deaths by reaching out to their loved ones and getting their emotional house in order. I loved that Dad helped prepare all of us in his own way with a special thought for each of us.

MOM: Oh, you opened it? . . . And did the rest of you open

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your cards, too?

LIZZY: Suddenly I felt horribly guilty. Oh, please tell me I was not the only [one] who went against his wishes and opened the card. Everyone smiled and nodded. They were all clearly shamed, but you could read in each person's face how much Dad's special words gave them peace. No one would be judging anyone today. He had given everyone something lovely to think about.

MOM: Dad wanted you to open those cards after he died, and since you all went against his wishes and already have, I would love to hear what he wrote to each of you. Lizz, you start.

LIZZY: *(to herself) Oh, no, Mom, Not now. This is so not the time. This cannot be happening. My father has been dead for five minutes, and I am about to make people feel worse than they already do? (to audience)* Do I lie? Yes, I would just lie. I would say the card said, *You will always be my baby and I love you.* Wait, I can't lie. The first thing I do after Dad is dead is to lie? I don't think so. I haven't even had a decent *cry* yet.

LINDA: Mom, maybe now is not the time.

ANN: Let's just focus on Dad and you.

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LIZZY: Crisis averted. No one wanted to read their cards! I felt relieved, and now I am not the bad guy who denied Mom.

MOM: *(determined)* Lizz, you start.

LIZZY: *(finally crying)* The card said, 'I love you. You were my favorite. Please don't . . ." *(to audience)* . . . and before I finished, everyone said in various tones of unison, "tell the others." Mom had a smile on her face that put the Cheshire Cat to shame. The room erupted with convulsions of dielarity.

Dad had pulled off the greatest gotcha moment of his life. And at his death, no less. He knew we all would open that card the second we got it. And he knew we would all find some smug superiority in what he wrote. But more than anything else, he knew how hard we would laugh when we found out -- laugh at our own ridiculousness and remember that **he** made us laugh, even after his death. He knew that this moment would be more precious than ***ever*** feeling like the favorite.

Bravo, Dad. Bravo.

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AWARD HISTORY

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